

Thomas J. Hughes

thughe4@gmu.edu • <https://thomas-j-hughes.com/index.html>

Education

George Mason University

Fairfax, Virginia

Economics PhD Candidate, ABD

Expected Graduation: May 2027

MA Economics

Awarded May 16, 2025

Fields: Austrian Economics; Economic Sociology and Political Economy

Mercer University

Macon, Georgia

Bachelor of Arts, **Major:** Mathematics and Economics

Graduation: May 2023

Minor: Statistics

Certificate: Actuarial Science

Fellowships and Affiliations

PhD Fellowship, Mercatus Center

August 2023-present

Graduate Fellow, F.A Hayek Program for Advanced Study in Philosophy, Politics, and Economics,

Mercatus Center

August 2023-present

Network Member, Initiative for the Study of a Stable Peace

January 2024-present

Professional Work

Graduate Lecturer (George Mason University)

August 2026-present

Course taught: Intermediate Microeconomics (ECON 306)

Graduate Teaching Assistant—Instructor of Record (George Mason University)

August 2025-May 2026

Courses taught: Four sections of Contemporary Macroeconomic Principles (ECON 104)

Course Evaluations:

Fall 2025: [Section 004](#); [Section 008](#)

Spring 2026: [Section 001](#); [Section 010](#)

Graduate Research Assistant (George Mason University)

August 2023-July 2025; August 2026-present

Assistant for Christopher J. Coyne during the 2023-2024, 2024-2025, and 2026-2027 academic year and the summer 2025 term.

Assistant for Peter J. Boettke during the summer 2024 term.

Preceptor (Mercer University)

August 2020-May 2021

Led four total sections of calculus 1 preceptor classes for the Department of Mathematics.

Published Papers

Bureaucratic Control After *Loper Bright Enterprises v. Raimondo*: The Rise of Judicial Control in a Post-Chevron Deference World (forthcoming at the Journal of Public Finance and Public Choice)

Under Review

The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Normal Accidents (under review at Cosmos + Taxis; co-authored with Christopher J. Coyne, George Mason University)

The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy (under review at Public Choice).

Working Papers

Does Government-Nonprofit Contracting Instantiate Democratic Priority-Setting? (co-authored with Brian Mandeville, George Mason University).

Works In Progress

Papers

Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models (co-authored with Robi Ragan, Mercer University)

Doctoral Failure: A Subjectivist Model of Exploitative Medical Behavior under Moral Constraints

When Truth Can Be Bad for Business: A Theory of Expert Failure in Religious Leadership (co-authored with Roger Koppl, Syracuse University)

William Niskanen and the Economics of Bureaucracy: Theory, Influence, and Policy Legacy

Books/Monographs

The Machinery of Administration: Bureaucracy in Mainline Economics (co-authored with Christopher J. Coyne; in progress)

Honors and Awards

Young Scholar, Association for Private Enterprise Education April 2026

Student Fellow of the Public Choice Society March 2026

Outstanding Award in Research, Stetson-Hatcher School of Business at Mercer University April 2023

Article: Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models

Center for the Study of Economics and Liberty Research Grant, Mercer University January 2023

Article: Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models

Professional Service

Referee

Journal of Public Finance and Public Choice

Conferences

Association of Private Enterprise Education Meeting

April 5-7, 2026

Las Vegas, Nevada

Presented: The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy & The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Civilizational Risk

Public Choice Society

March 12-14, 2026

San Antonio, Texas

Presented: The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy

Southern Economic Association

November 22-24, 2025

Tampa, Florida

Presented: Bureaucratic Control After *Loper Bright Enterprises v. Raimondo*: The Rise of Judicial Control in a Post-Chevron Deference World & Doctoral Failure: A Subjectivist Model of Exploitative Medical Behavior under Moral Constraint

Markets and Society Conference

October 17-20, 2025

Falls Church, Virginia

Presented: The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Civilizational Risk

Society of Business, Industry, and Economics

April 12-14, 2023

Destin, Florida

Presented: Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models

References

Chris Coyne

Department of Economics

George Mason University

ccoyne3@gmu.edu

Rosolino Candela

Mercatus Center at George Mason University

rcandela@mercatus.gmu.edu

Peter Boettke

Distinguished University Professor of Economics and Philosophy

Department of Economics

George Mason University

pboettke@gmu.edu

Robi Ragan

Department of Economic

Mercer University

ragan_ra@mercer.edu